

Avro 683 Lancaster



“We saw them coming like relief coming to a hard-pressed army; they were unconquerable; the days of heavy losses were over.”

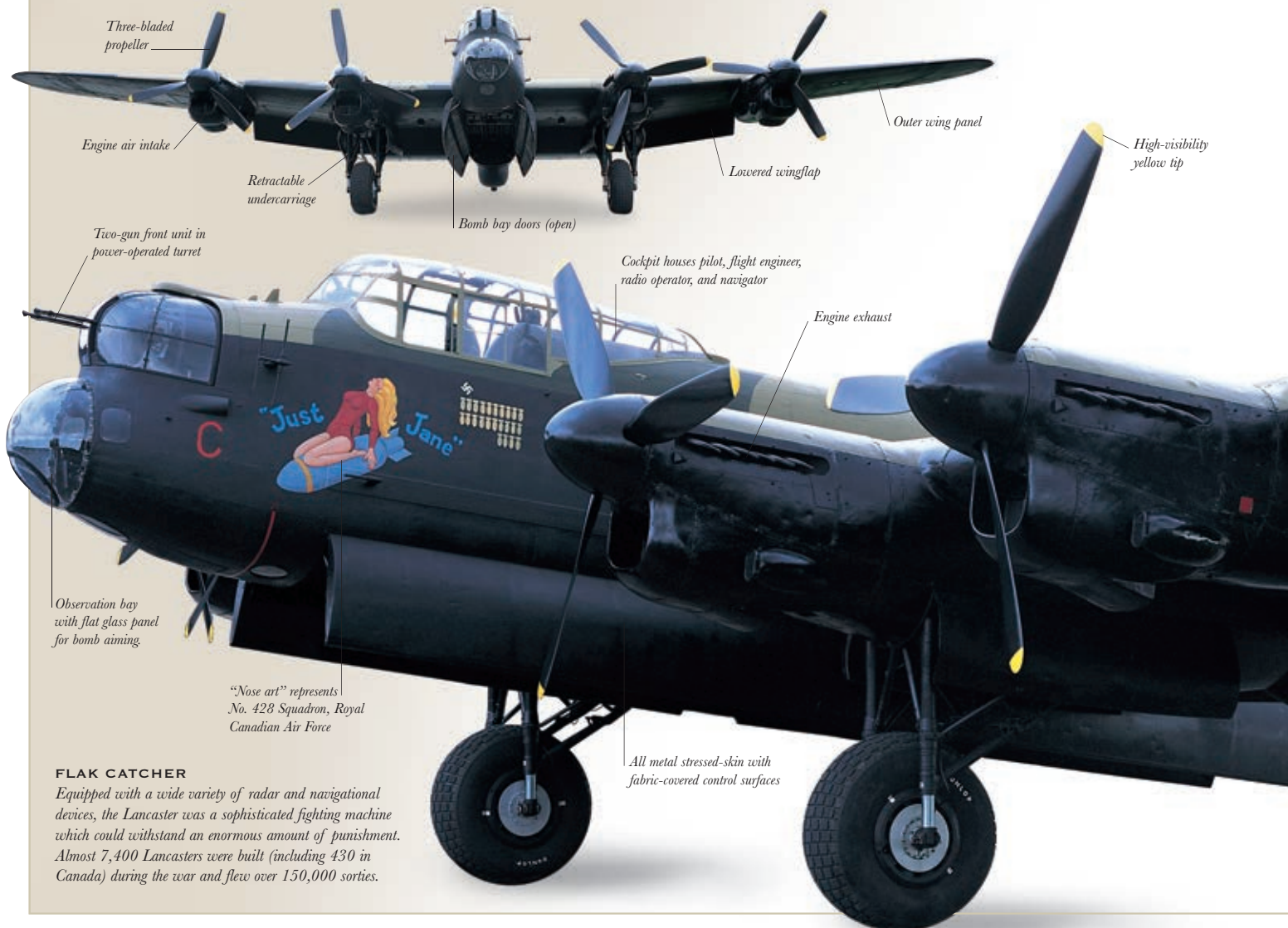
DON CHARLWOOD
RAF LANCASTER NAVIGATOR, 1942

THE LANCASTER WAS THE RAF's best heavy bomber of WWII, developed from the unsuccessful twin-engined Avro Manchester. The four-engined Lancaster saw its first action in April 1942 and was greeted with widespread enthusiasm by its bomber crews. It might have been available at the start of the war had it not been for problems finding a suitable engine. The adoption of the powerful Rolls-Royce Merlin created a bomber with a

superior bombload-to-range ratio than that of the American B-17 or B-24 bombers.

Lancasters had fewer guns than American bombers, partly because manpower shortages made the British balk at a 10-man crew. The Lancaster usually flew with a seven-man crew: the pilot, flight engineer, radio operator, navigator, bombardier, and two gunners. Although the pilot was the “skipper,” he was usually a sergeant, while

other members of the crew – for example the navigator – might be officers. The gunners in the rear and mid-upper turrets had the worst positions in the aircraft, sitting through long flights in cold isolation, breathing oxygen through their masks, and only linked to their colleagues by their earphones. The fate of the crew depended, to a great extent, on their alertness when Luftwaffe night fighters homed in.



FLAK CATCHER

Equipped with a wide variety of radar and navigational devices, the Lancaster was a sophisticated fighting machine which could withstand an enormous amount of punishment. Almost 7,400 Lancasters were built (including 430 in Canada) during the war and flew over 150,000 sorties.